

HISTORY

THE ALUMINIUM **TRAIL**

THE **HUMP WW2 MUSEUM** IN PASIGHAT, ARUNACHAL PRADESH, BRINGS TOGETHER ARTEFACTS RETRIEVED FROM PLANE WRECKS SCATTERED ACROSS REMOTE MOUNTAINOUS TERRAIN TO SPOTLIGHT A LESSER-KNOWN ASPECT OF WW2





A brand-new museum in Pasighat, Arunachal Pradesh, commemorates a long-forgotten chapter of WW2 in India. The 'Hump' was a dramatic logistical operation that maintained an air bridge of transport aircraft between Upper Assam and China's Yunnan province in order to supply Chiang Kai-Shek's Kuomintang forces in the battle against Japan.

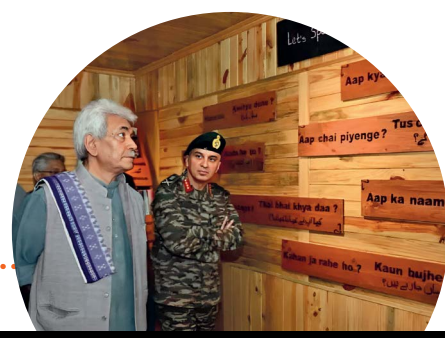
Remarkably, from its beginnings in April 1942 till the end of the war, the Hump airlift succeeded in transporting a total of 650,000 tonnes of supplies across this route, an unprecedented achievement that certainly contributed to the Allied victory. It took a toll on airmen and planes though, with an estimated 600 crashes on the perilous route. Many of these were in the hills of Arunachal, and the 'Hump WW2 Museum' tells the stirring story of success, disaster, adventure and survival with artefacts retrieved from the 'aluminium trail' of wrecked planes scattered across remote jungles and mountaintops. It also reveals the importance of the wartime operation in accelerating the reach of aviation in post-war India, thanks to the many aircraft and airfields left over from the Hump. ■

SHINON MEERAS CENTRE

Where: Head to the Bandipora district in Northern Kashmir to visit this space that celebrates the Dard-Shina tribes of the Gurez Valley, once a gateway to the Silk Route

What: At 8,000 feet, the gorgeous location on the banks of the Kishanganga River has already charmed visitors (apparently it attracted upwards of 35,000 travellers in the tourist season this year!). Now, apart from the natural beauty, trekking, and trout fishing, this centre, supported by the army, will be a big draw

Expect: An amphitheatre for local cultural performances, displays of textiles, audio-visuals and interactive exhibits showcasing the ancient roots, life and language of the Dards



HAMPI ART LABS



Where: Opening in February, this is an initiative of the JSW Foundation, led by founder Sangita Jindal and her daughter Tarini. They've got architect Sameep Padora and his studio sP+a to create the almost-poetic structure within an 18-acre area near the Tungabhadra river and Hampi

What: Imagine state-of-the-art set-ups for exhibiting, a residency programme and modern amenities. The idea of fostering inter-disciplinary art will see printmaking, stone and metal sculpture, ceramics and a variety of new media

Expect: Works from the Jindal Collection that run the gamut of artists from Andy Warhol to Atul Dodiya, Dayanita Singh to Zarina Hashmi and many others, in *Right Foot First*, the first exhibition here

by Priya Pathiyan